

By Srimati Basu

cons of romance in India are rarely monogamous and married: the Taj Mahal was built by Shah Jahan for a favoured wife though he had two others; Krishna's vehicle of ultimate love was his uncle's wife, Radha. In contrast to multiple systems of organising marriage and sexuality that were (and still are) prevalent in India, adultery as a marital offence is a relatively new experiment whose boundaries are being tried.

How is adultery understood? As intercourse outside marriage? Anxieties in this regard have often been about policing women's sexuality in order to harness their reproductive power, to ensure that the offspring were biologically part of the patriline so that property might be passed along. Harsh laws against adultery (such as in Pakistan's Hudood ordinance which criminalises adultery and holds rape testimonials to be tantamount to adultery confessions) mark it as a violation against male property, requiring monetary compensation or even corporal punishment. Or is adultery a betrayal of affection or emotion that threatens the conjugal bond? In the film *Mr & Mrs Iyer*, for example, Meenakshi and Raja share intense trauma, emotional and artistic sensibilities, and finally a kiss—the charged guilt around her husband's reappearance indicates that we are privy to a secret affair. Similarly, the recent film *Anuronon* plays on whether the extra-conjugal relationship becomes scandalous even without sex. In the 2007 INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG survey, when asked whether "emotional infidelity" equalled an "affair", 51 per cent respondents answered in the affirmative—this response too indicates ambivalence about whether fidelity is about conjugal trust rather than property or children. Do the 41 per cent male and 8 per cent female among the 2008 survey respondents who admit to committing adultery mark it in terms of intercourse, or follow broader definitions of sex?

Multiple marital and sexual partners have been regularly available for men (mainly elite men) over the centuries. We have only to think of the heroic characters in the epics, or em-

Do you approve of adultery?

YES 26

NO 74

Male 43, Female 8

Male 57, Female 92

Two out of five men approve of adultery. In Hyderabad, 72 per cent gave their sanction to it. Delhi followed next at 62 per cent.

INDIA'S
ADULTERY
CAPITAL

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PER CENT RESPONDENTS IN LUDHIANA HAVE COMMITTED ADULTERY. DELHI COMES SECOND AT 39 PER CENT.

